

Held but Hollow

Why our record-capable pipeline is at risk — and what we do this year

Allan Hancock College Foundation • Development Briefing • New Fundraising Year

The national mirror

Record dollars, falling donors — the sector's warning to every foundation.

\$617.2B

Total U.S. giving, 2025

+5.7% — first year ever above \$600B

−3.6%

Donor count

5th straight annual decline (FEP Q4 2025)

~19%

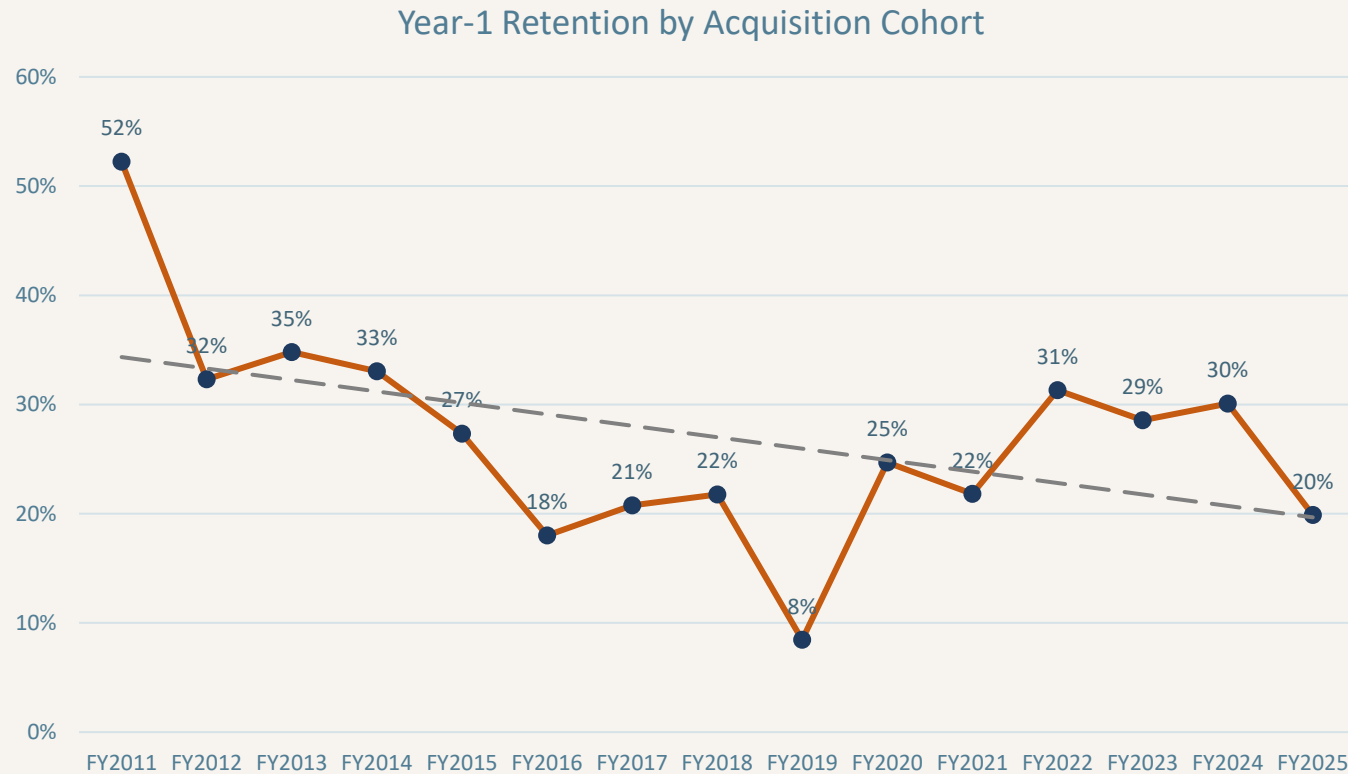
New-donor retention

Four in five first-time donors never return

“A retention problem is a promise problem. A major-gift pipeline is a retention problem with a ten-year fuse.”

We are not the exception

Our first-year renewal decays to the same ~19% floor as the nation.

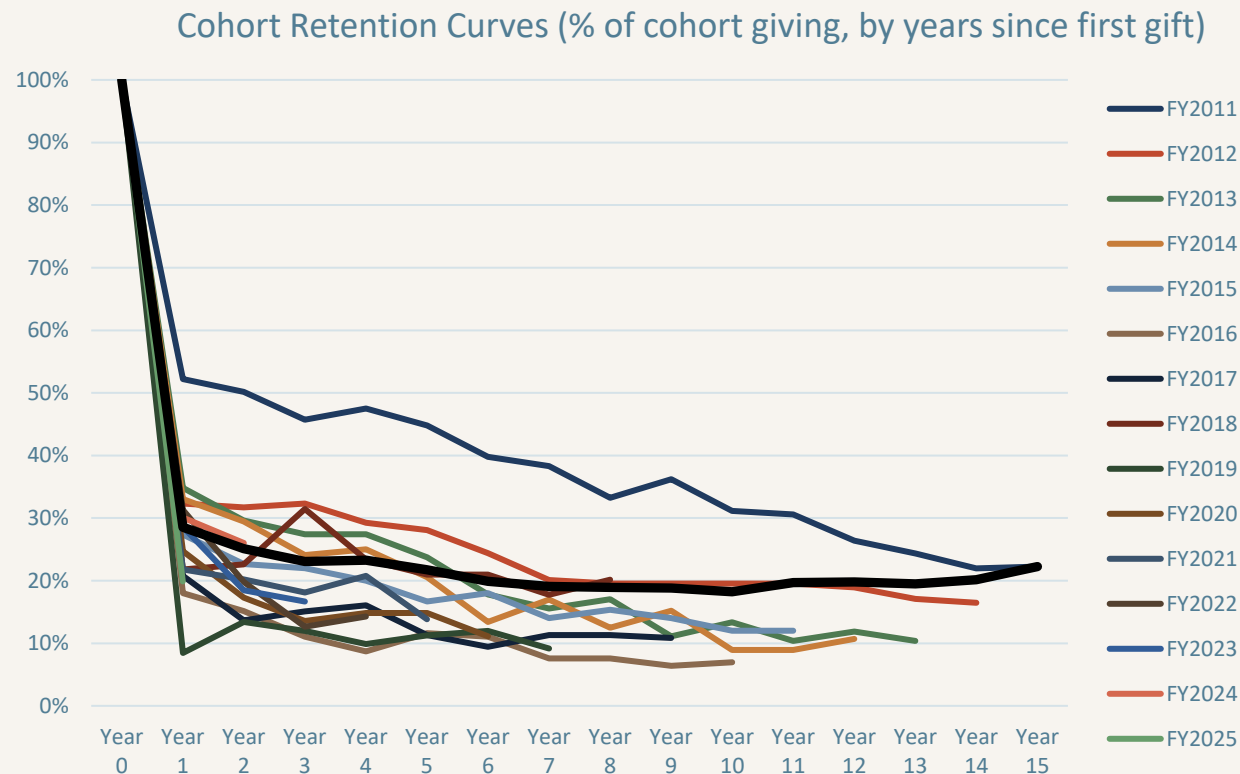


What the trend shows

- Year-1 retention by cohort has slid from ~34% to ~20%.
- FY2019 cratered to 8% — a warning we can no longer treat as noise.
- This mirrors the national ~19% new-donor floor exactly.

The leak is at the first gift

Every cohort bleeds hardest at the very first renewal.

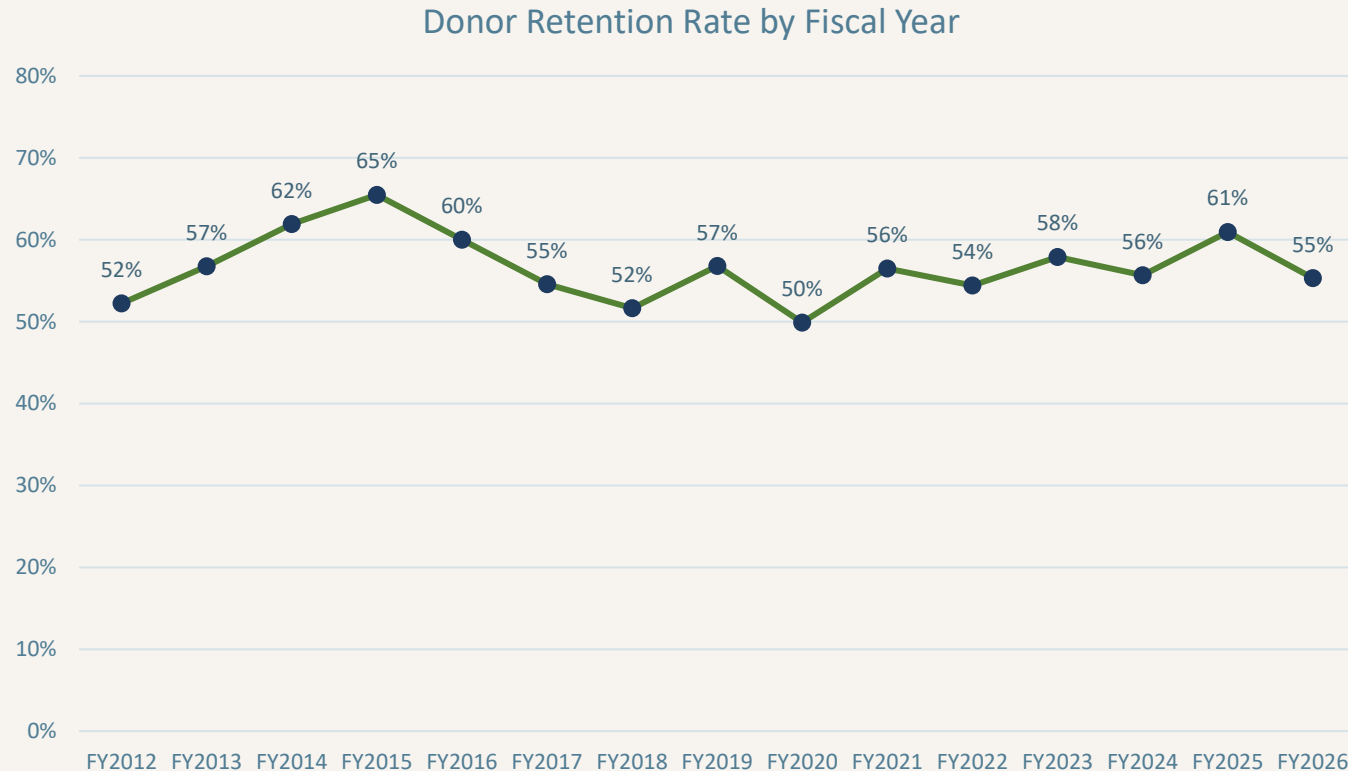


Read the curves

- The steepest drop is always year 0→1 — the first renewal.
- After that, curves flatten toward the same long-run ~19% floor.
- Blended first-year renewal is only ~29%: most donors are lost before we ever ask twice.
- Lift the first gift and the entire curve rises with it.

But our loyal base is strong

The donors we keep, we keep well — our retention beats the sector.

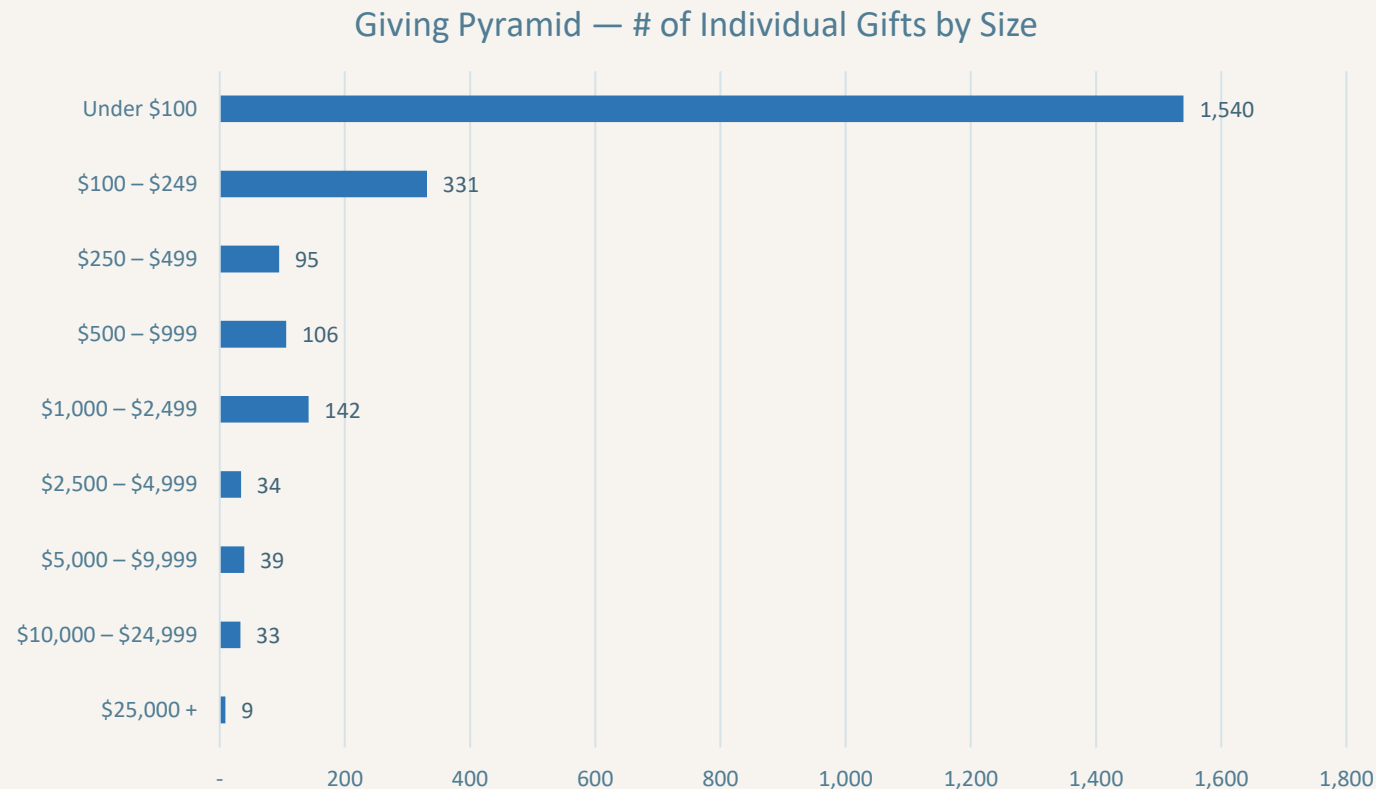


The good news

- Overall donor retention holds in a ~50–65% band, averaging ~57%.
- That is well above the national 43.3% — our relationships are not the problem.
- The strength is real, but it sits on donors we won years ago.
- The risk is what happens to the base we are planting now.

The pyramid is concentrated

2,366 gifts — but the dollars sit at the very top.

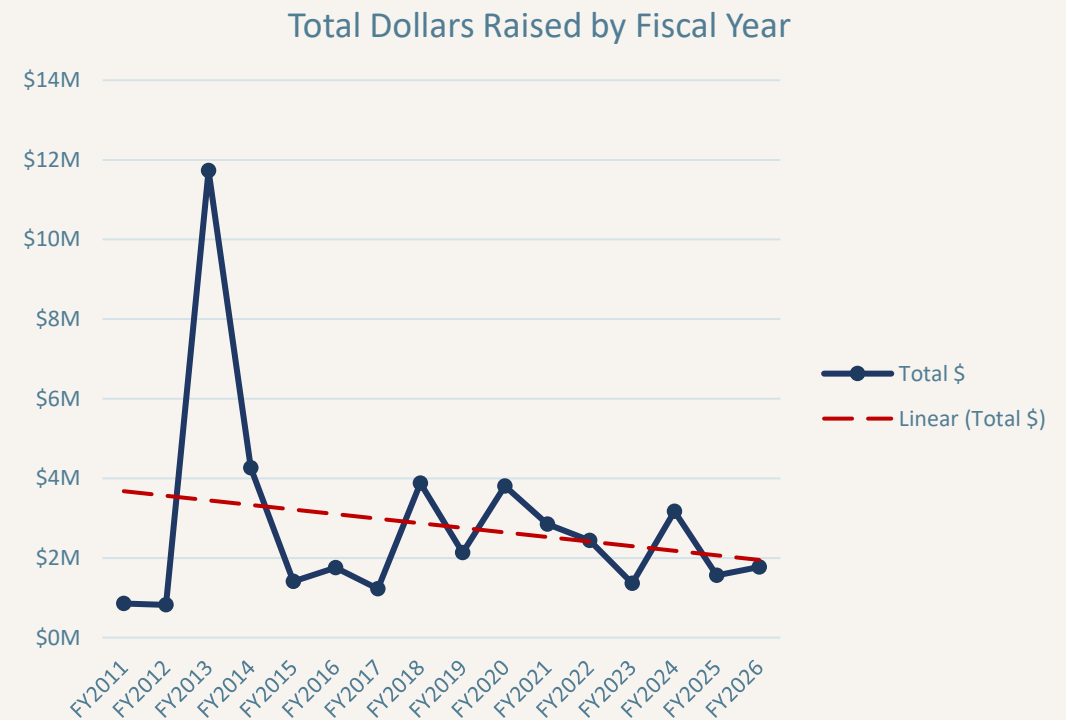
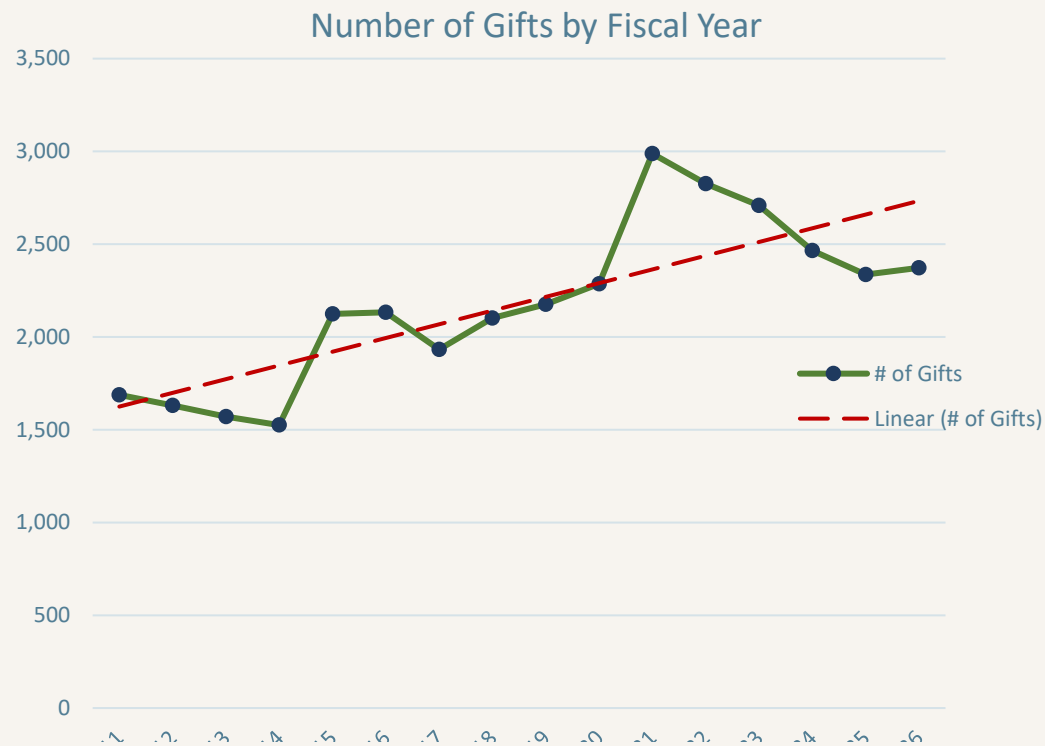


FY2026 at a glance

- ~2,366 gifts raised ~\$1.77M in total.
- The base (under \$100) is ~1,450 gifts — the widest part of the pyramid.
- The apex (\$25K+) is just 12 gifts, yet it carries most of the dollars.
- A handful of apex & trust gifts hold the whole number up.

More gifts, not more money

Gift count is climbing (~1,600 → ~2,370) while dollars stay flat.



FY2013's \$11.7M spike was a one-time trust harvest. Strip it out and the pattern is clear: we are doing more work for the same money.

The ten-year fuse

Major gifts are grown, not bought.



Today's apex gifts were planted 5–10 years ago. The base we are planting now is going bare — so the 2030s pipeline will be hollow.

Short-term: stop the leak this year

Fixes we can start now — at the front door, where the loss begins.

01

Launch a second-gift program

Ask every first-year donor again within 90 days. The first renewal is where we lose the most donors.

02

Re-engage lapsed donors by name

Personally reconnect with large one-time gifts: Sue Sword Revocable Trust (\$683K, FY2024) and Hansen Trust (\$250K, FY2017).

03

Clean duplicate records

1,457 of 2,697 donors gave exactly once. Dedupe the file so we can see the true pipeline.

Long-term: build the pipeline

Design the system that grows major gifts over the next decade.



Build a mid-tier upgrade path

Create a deliberate \$1K–\$10K giving tier that moves loyal small and mid donors upward — the feeder stock for tomorrow’s major and planned gifts.



Adopt “promise-at-intake”

Capture why each donor gave at the very first gift, so we can see the leak forming — and intervene before it becomes a lapse.

The ask

Make first-year donor retention a board-level metric

Reviewed every quarter, owned by this board, for the new fundraising year.

~29% → 50% first-year renewal: where we start, where we aim

Hold the promise at the front door, and the pipeline fills itself.